158 Borough Drive
Community Meeting #2 (of 2)

MEETING SUMMARY

Monday, July 26th, 2021
6:00 - 8:00 pm, Virtual Meeting

Meeting Overview

On Monday, July 26th, 2021, the City of Toronto and CreateTO hosted a second Community Meeting for the proposed redevelopment of 158 Borough Drive as part of the Housing Now Initiative. The purpose of the meeting was to share and seek feedback on the revised development proposal for the site. Approximately 115 members of the public joined the meeting. Other participants included Deputy Mayor, City Councillor Michael Thompson, staff from the City of Toronto and CreateTO, and members of the project consultant team (see Attachment A for the meeting agenda).

The meeting was advertised through the following methods: a mailed notice to residents and businesses surrounding the site (approximately 6,700 notices mailed); emails sent to individuals who signed up for updates on the Housing Now website (www.createto.ca/housingnow) and through the first Community Meeting; information on the project webpage (www.createto.ca/158borough) Deputy Mayor Michael Thompson's Newsletter; and via CreateTO's social media channels.

The presentation and a recording of the meeting are available on the project webpage and CreateTO's YouTube Channel.

- View the presentation slides
- Watch the recording

Swerhun Inc., the independent facilitation team retained by CreateTO, facilitated the meeting and wrote this summary, which was shared with participants in draft prior to being finalized. Participants were encouraged to send additional feedback by completing the feedback form online or by mail and/or by email to City Planning. This summary is intended to reflect the key discussion points from the meeting and is not intended to be a verbatim transcript. A summary of the feedback shared following the meeting will also be available on the project webpage.

Note to reader: *CreateTO, the City of Toronto, and the third-party facilitators from Swerhun acknowledge the impact of discriminatory and offensive remarks made during the meeting. The Housing Now process does not tolerate, ignore, or condone discrimination and is committed to promoting respectful conduct, tolerance, and inclusion. Future meetings will open with clear reminders to all participants and meeting guidelines for maintaining a respectful and constructive environment that the Housing Now process strives to offer all.*

This draft summary was written by the independent facilitation team that is not advocating for any particular outcome of this project. The intent of this summary is to capture the perspectives shared, not to assess the merit or accuracy of any of these perspectives. This summary also does not indicate an endorsement of any of these perspectives on the part of CreateTO or the City of Toronto.

Key Points of Discussion

The following summarizes key points of the discussion shared by participants at the meeting. They are intended to be read together with the rest of this summary report.

- **Differing opinions about the need and impact of affordable housing.** Some participants raised questions and concerns related to affordable housing around community safety, crime, property values, and the amount of affordable housing being targeted (i.e., up to 50% of the residential units). Some suggested this site to be an inappropriate location for affordable housing. Other participants strongly emphasized the need for affordable housing to support people of different ages, abilities, and backgrounds. These participants suggested adding more affordable housing units. Others suggested focusing more on affordable ownership instead of rental. It was also noted that many people in Scarborough would benefit from affordable housing and that not all of Scarborough voices were represented at the meeting.

- **Questions about the Housing Now Initiative, affordable housing, the proposed development, and process.** There were a lot of questions about the initiative in general, details about what's proposed and how it would be implemented, as well as questions about site selection, and alternative ways to advocate for a particular outcome.

- **Concerns over increasing density.** Some participants wanted to understand why this site was chosen in particular and shared concerns about increasing number of new buildings in the area, overcrowding, increasing pollution, increasing congestion, increasing demand on public transit (especially in light of the upcoming closure of Scarborough Rapid Transit before the opening of the new subway extension) and school capacity, and impact on the woodlot.

- **Interest in increasing cycling infrastructure and public transit service.** Some participants expressed interest in seeing more bike parking and cycling paths around the new development. Some participants also noted that affordable housing needs to come with improved public transit, which would not be the case once the Scarborough Rapid Transit closes.

- **Significant process advice was also shared** to expand the outreach to the community geographically (beyond the immediate vicinity of the site) and interest-wise (to organizations and people interested in affordable housing). One participant noted their disappointment that discriminatory and offensive comments were made and that no factual information about affordable housing impacts (or lack thereof) was provided and that such comments continued throughout the meeting.

Questions of Clarification

As part of the discussion, there were participants who asked questions of clarification. Participant questions appear first in bold text, followed by responses and comments shared by the project team in *italics.*

Housing Now Initiative and Affordable Housing

- **Why is this site being used for affordable housing and not for something else, like other social services?** *The site is in Scarborough Centre and is zoned as residential and office mixed-use area. Note provided by the project team after the meeting: The plan for Scarborough Centre has long identified this as a mixed-use development site, and in keeping with the expected uses, Council has identified this as a property to be included in the Housing Now Initiative. The creation of new housing on well-located City-owned lands, such as 158 Borough Drive, will provide Toronto residents with opportunities to live affordably near transit hubs and close to places of work, education, and services. Investment in these sites will also contribute to the broader community by delivering new amenities, revitalized public spaces and improved access to transit. The 158 Borough Drive Housing Now site will create a mix of affordable and market rental units to serve Toronto residents. The new affordable rental homes will remain affordable for 99 years, providing quality housing opportunities for future generations.*
- **What are the different types of affordable housing?** *There are different types of affordable housing in the City of Toronto. This development will be operated through the Housing Now Initiative and will include both affordable rental and market rental housing. The affordable rental will on average rent for 80 per cent of Toronto's average market rent. The City of Toronto's Housing Secretariat will establish the guidelines, which will include a requirement that households in the affordable units do not earn more than four times their annual rent upon signing of the lease. This would mean that someone living in a 1-bedroom unit would have an approximate annual income of $55,000.*
  Note provided by the project team after the meeting: The graphic below is taken from the Housing Now Discussion Guide available on the project website www.createto.ca/158borough. It depicts the range of housing affordability and outlines the type of affordable housing provided as part of the Housing Now Initiative.



- **Will renters be limited to professional workers only, such as healthcare workers?** *No, eligibility is based on income levels, not occupation.*

Proposed development:

- **If 50 per cent of the units are for affordable rental, what is the other half for?** *The other 50 per cent will be market rental units.*
- **When does the City anticipate construction to begin on this project?** *Construction is anticipated to begin in 2024 and first occupancy to be in 2026/2027.*
- **Will the local schools be able to accommodate additional density?** *As part of the application process, school boards are notified and asked to let the City Planner know whether they have room for additional students. Future residents are also advised that there may be limited capacity in the local schools. School boards do make an effort to accommodate local students.*
- **Who owns the building with the 99-year contract?** *To ensure it remains part of the Housing Now Initiative, the developer will sign a lease with the City for 99-years, and the developer will be selected based on different factors such as experience in managing a high-quality rental property.*
- **Why couldn't more space be created to offer more generous setbacks?** *The site exceeds the City's minimum requirements for setbacks for tall buildings.*
- **Are there any studies being done that look at protecting the natural environment?** *Technical studies such as the Tree Preservation Plan (which assesses all existing and future vegetation on site), Geotechnical Drilling Study and Phase 1 and 2 of an Environmental study that look at soil quality were submitted to the City for technical review and approval. The plan for the site is to introduce more greenspace, shrubs, canopy trees, soft surfaces (to absorb storm water), raised planters, benches and a tree boulevard to enhance the public pedestrian walkway from Borough Drive to Albert Campbell Square. Encouraging more pedestrian walkways and transit itself will help in reducing pollution in the local community. The City also requires its developments to meet high standards of sustainability and explore the potential to meet near net-zero carbon emissions, which this site and seventeen other sites in the Housing Now Initiative are doing. Note provided by the project team after the meeting: Furthermore, densifying urban environments contributes to environmental sustainability because it means more people can live year public transit, employment opportunities, and the amenities and services they need without frequently relying on fossil-fuel intensive activities like driving.*

Process:

- **How can the public formally protest this development?** *As this is a public process, any comments about the proposed development are heard and recorded here. Public Notice will be given of the Planning and Housing Committee statutory meeting, where any individual can make a formal deputation to publicly comment on the proposal.*

Detailed Summary of Feedback

The following section of this report includes a more detailed summary of the feedback shared at the meeting.

- **Diverging opinions about the need and the impact of affordable rental housing.** Much of the feedback shared at the meeting related to the inclusion of affordable rental units with some participants raising strong concerns and some strongly supporting the initiative.

  Some participants shared the following concerns:
  - concerns that the affordable housing would negatively impact neighbouring property values;
  - fears that crime would increase, and the community would become less safe;
  - concern that those who rent may not take as good care of the neighbourhood as those who own;
  - people in this community worked hard to get where they are and paid for their housing; providing affordable housing to others feels unfair to them.

  Other participants emphasized the need for affordable housing and expressed their strong support for the Housing Now Initiative. They shared the following:
  - the City is experiencing a housing affordability crisis and more needs to be done to provide affordable housing across the City to support young people, families, and others of all ages and abilities from different walks of life;
  - this site makes sense for affordable housing, as it is located on City-owned land and near a subway station. They pointed out that one of the consequences of advocating for three new subway stops in Scarborough means welcoming a transit-oriented development with taller buildings and more people living around the subway stations.
  - Scarborough has many diverse voices and the diversity of the voices was not represented at the meeting.

- **Concerns about lack of consultation on the selection of the site and previous concerns not being addressed.** Some participants noted that they were not consulted on whether or not this site would be developed as part of the Housing Now Initiative and did not know that the program exists. Participants also said that it looked like the concerns and feedback that they shared at a previous meeting were not incorporated into the presented conceptual design.
  The project team explained that this site was chosen as a Housing Now site based on Council direction. It is an underutilized City-owned site, close to transit, with space to provide key community assets (like a community daycare) and can achieve a city-building goal of helping to create a complete community. It is also part of Scarborough Centre Secondary Plan, which identifies the height of the buildings and directs residential and employment growth.
  Deputy Mayor Michael Thompson said he will be working with CreateTO to establish a working group to continue discussions about the proposed development to allow residents who live in the area to voice their opinions. Following the meeting an email was sent to all participants to invite them to apply for memberships on the working group. The Deputy Mayor's office and CreateTO will provide information about next steps related to the Working Group.

- **Concerns about height of the proposed development and increased density.** A participant noted that the presentation does not show all the buildings in the area, including many new developments around the site and shared a concern that adding so many more

units to the area would increase traffic congestion. Another participant said that a study from ten years ago suggested this are should not include high-rises, which would now block the views for the existing buildings and shared a concern of increased pollution and an impact to the woodlot.

- **Concern about increased traffic.** A participant said that traffic congestion in the area is already a significant problem and that the proposed development will make traffic congestion worse by increasing density. There was some concern that reduction in space / lanes for vehicles on Borough Drive to create space for bike lanes could increase congestion in the area.
- **Affordable housing needs to come with more transit.** Some participants shared concerns that adding more people to the area will put additional strain on an already busy and crowded transit system. There were also concerns about the existing Scarborough Rapid Transit system being taken offline in 2023 and potential for further delays to the future subway.
- **Interest in cycling infrastructure.** There was some discussion about ways to improve cycling infrastructure in the area including suggestions to increase the amount of bike parking on the site and to explore ways to improve cycling connections in the area.

Suggestions Regarding the Proposed Development

- Consider compensating property owners if there is a decrease in property value
- Focus more on affordable ownership
- Explore the surrounding area for an alternative location, including areas around Brimley Road, HWY-401, and Progress Avenue.
- Consider postponing the development until additional public transit is brought into the area.

Process Advice

- **Advice to consult with community organizations and individuals that require affordable housing.** There was a suggestion to broaden the outreach beyond the immediate 300-m vicinity of the site in an effort to connect with and hear from people who need the proposed affordable housing. It was suggested one way to do this would be to connect with Scarborough organizations that work with and serve people who would be interested in and benefit from the affordable rental housing.

Next Steps

The project team thanked participants for attending and sharing their feedback and committed to sharing a draft meeting summary in the coming weeks. Deputy Mayor and local Councillor Michael Thompson proposed striking a working group to ensure the community's voices are heard during the next steps of the project. The team explained the meeting materials will be made available on the project website at www.createto.ca/158borough including the presentation, a recording of the meeting and an online feedback form. Participants can also contact the Community Planner, Kelly Dynes at 416-396-4250 or Kelly.dynes@toronto.ca.

Attachment A. Agenda

Housing Now

158 Borough Drive
Community Meeting #2

Monday, July 26, 2021

6:00 – 8:00 p.m.

Online and by phone

Meeting Purpose

To share and seek feedback on the revised development concept for 158 Borough Drive.

Proposed Agenda

6:00 Welcome, land acknowledgement, introductions, agenda review

Deputy Mayor Thompson & Swerhun Inc.

6:10 Overview of the refined Development Concept

City Planning, CreateTO, Diamond Schmitt Architects

Questions and Answer

6:50 Discussion

Discussion Questions:

1. What do you like about the revised development concept?
2. Do you have any suggested refinements to the revised development concept?
3. Do you have any other comments or feedback for the Housing Now team?

7:55 Wrap up and next steps

8:00 Adjourn